One Wants to Tour, One Won't Talk

A family conversation about what to do now and what can wait.

Your brother wants to start visiting places. Your sister changes the subject. You suspect they're both answering a question nobody has asked yet.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: get everyone's ideas onto one page, marked as useful now or able to wait. It isn't for deciding where Mom lives, and it isn't for handing out jobs.

Who should be there

Mom, first. It's her life on the page, and AARP's planning guide for families says a plan should never be made without the participation, knowledge and consent of the person it's about. [1]

Then everyone who would have a part in getting ready: the one who lives ten minutes away, the one three states away who phones on Sundays and, if Mom would like her there, the neighbor with the spare key. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is or will be part of the team, which may include a family friend or a neighbor. [2]

Someone who can't come can send their ideas ahead. Someone who would rather not come can be told what the conversation is for and what it isn't, and read the page afterwards.

Ask one person to keep the notes and a different person to keep the conversation moving.

How to open

Say what the conversation is for before anything else. The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice for family meetings is to list the issues as they are shared, before trying to solve any of them. [2]

- “Mom, nothing needs to change. We'd like to get a few things ready while there's no rush, and we want to start with what you'd want.”
- “Each of us has ideas about what we should be doing. Let's get them all on one list before anyone argues for theirs.”
- Say what's off the table today: where Mom lives, and who does what.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. What would you like us to get ready while things are as they are?

2. What would you rather we didn't do yet?

3. If something changed for you, what would you want us to notice, and what would you rather tell us yourself?

Ask each other

1. What's the one thing you'd most like the family to get ready, and why that one?

2. What on the list do you think can wait?

3. Is there a piece of this you'd be willing to take? “Not yet” is a fine answer.

4. What would make you want to sit down like this again?

5. Which of these can none of us answer, and who could?

How to write down what was said

Write each idea the way it was said, with whose it is. In the third column put “now,” “can wait” or “not agreed.” Where two people would put the same idea in different places, write “not agreed” and leave it there. Fill in the last column only when someone offers, in their own words.

WHAT WAS SUGGESTED	WHO SUGGESTED IT	NOW, CAN WAIT OR NOT AGREED	WHO OFFERED
“Ask me before you ask each other.”	Mom	Now	All of us
Get the appointment notes into one folder.	Me	Now	My sister said she'd do it over the holidays
Start visiting places.	My brother	Not agreed	

What not to decide yet

Nothing today depends on these. Keep them on the page, worded as things the family is waiting on, not things it has ruled out.

- Where Mom will live, or whether she'll move.
- Which places are better than others.
- A date for anything to change.
- Who was right about touring.
- Who does a job they haven't offered to do.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the page and send it round.
- Who will keep it afterwards, if someone offers.
- Who will take each open question to Mom's doctor or a care consultant, if someone offers.
- When you'll look at the page together again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle whether your brother or your sister is right, and it doesn't tell you what a professional would say. It gets the family to one page, with the disagreement left on it.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked through what to do now and what to leave, and nobody was handed a job. The care interview adds what the page doesn't have: it walks you through Mom's situation as it is today, area by area, so the plan has a starting point to be measured from, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting